The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC), founded in 1985 and headquartered in Dhaka, has seven South Asia countries as its member states,[62] while the Indian Ocean Rim Association includes a wider range of member states in Asia, Australia, and Africa.[63] Other groupings include the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation, founded in 1997 and headquartered in Dhaka.[64] In addition, there exist some other bodies, big and small, that have not been included in the map, such as the 26-nation Conference on Interaction and Confidence-Building Measures in Asia and the 6-nation Mekong-Ganga Cooperation. These are both organisations that include countries from the Indo-Pacific expanse.[65] India recently also jointed the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, founded as the Shanghai Five in the mid-1990s, as is discussed in detail by Stobdan in this volume.

Even if no overarching security order is in place in Asia, many of these regional groupings or institutions have been in existence for several decades and conduct regular meetings at the highest political levels, supplemented with bureaucratic-level meetings across a wide range of sectors. They can manage diverse security-related issues and could potentially be used much more effectively to put in place cooperative mechanisms for promoting non-proliferation; confidence building; regulating migration; and preventing conflict, pandemics, cybercrimes, illegal infiltration, and trafficking in women, children, and drugs.

Interdependence through economic cooperation

Asia is also moving towards economic interdependence, with intraregional trade within the Indo-Pacific region increasing. In 2017, about 54 percent of the region’s exports and 57